PORTLAND PUBLIC SCHOOLS
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To: Portland Public Schools School Board
From: Christopher Brida, Director of CTE, AP & IB
Date: February 2, 2025
Subject: PPS Advanced Placement Overview, Course Guide Review, Next Steps

The Advanced Placement (AP) program is critical to our district's commitment to academic excellence and college readiness. To ensure equitable access, alignment, and student success in AP courses, we have comprehensively reviewed AP offerings across our schools. This memo provides an overview of the current AP landscape, highlights key findings from our review, and outlines the following steps to improve alignment and access, focusing on addressing disparities in student participation and outcomes.

Overview of AP in Our District

The Advanced Placement (AP) program is critical in providing rigorous academic opportunities for students across our district. The following data provides a snapshot of our current AP landscape:

AP Subjects Offered by School:

- **Benson** – 10 subjects
- **Franklin** – 22 subjects
- **Grant** – 18 subjects
- **Ida B. Wells** – 24 subjects
- **McDaniel** – 19 subjects
- **Roosevelt** – 14 subjects

The district offers Every AP subject except Latin, Italian, and German.

2023-2024 AP Participation & Performance:

- **Total AP students:** 2,894 (+6.8% from previous year)
- **Total AP exams taken:** 4,747 (+9.2% from previous year)
- **Average AP exam score:** 3.2
- **Percent of exams with a score of 3 or higher:** 69% (+17.4% from previous year)

AP Participation and Performance by Grade Level:

- **Grade 9:** 106 students | 113 exams | Avg. Score: 3.2 | 73% scored 3+
- **Grade 10:** 921 students | 1,187 exams | Avg. Score: 3.2 | 70% scored 3+
- **Grade 11:** 1,071 students | 1,933 exams | Avg. Score: 3.1 | 66% scored 3+
- **Grade 12:** 796 students | 1,514 exams | Avg. Score: 3.2 | 71% scored 3+

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AP Participation and Performance by Race:

Race	Students	Exams Taken	Exams Per Student	Exams Scoring 3+ (%)
American Indian	9	15	1.67	46.7%
Asian	277	475	1.71	60.4%
Black	77	105	1.36	34.3%
Hispanic	343	517	1.51	53.8%
Pacific Islander	7	9	1.28	11.1%
White	1,827	3,042	1.67	74.1%
Multiple	271	463	1.71	70.4%
No Response	62	87	1.40	70.1%

AP Test Taking Participation by Underserved vs Not Underserved

Category	Number of Enrollments	Number of Exam Takers	Percentage
Not Underserved	4031	2898	71.9%
Underserved	1034	615	59.4%

While overall performance is strong, disparities in AP participation and success rates among racial groups exist. Addressing these gaps is a critical priority moving forward.

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Findings from the AP Course Guide Review

Over the past few months, we have conducted an in-depth course guide analysis of AP courses, alignment, and access across the district. This review has revealed areas of strong consistency and places where greater clarity is needed.

- **High Alignment:** Most schools consistently offer AP courses with standardized prerequisites, grade-level access, and core/elective designation.
    - **Example: AP English Literature & Composition** – Core course in grades 11-12 across nearly all schools.

School	Grade(s) Offered	Core/Elective	Prerequisites
Benson	11, 12	Core	English 5-6
Franklin	12	Core	English 5-6
Grant	11, 12	Core	English 5-6
Ida B Wells	12	Core	English 5-6 or AP Language
McDaniel	12	Core	English 5-6 or AP Language
Roosevelt	11, 12	Core	English 3-4

- **Moderate Alignment:** Courses where the grade levels, core/elective designation, or prerequisites vary slightly but do not create significant access barriers.
    - **Example:** AP Calculus AB – Offered at all schools but varies in core vs. elective designation.

School	Grade(s) Offered	Core/Elective	Prerequisites
Benson	11, 12	Elective	None
Franklin	10, 11, 12	Elective	Precalculus
Grant	11, 12	Core	Precalculus
Ida B Wells	10, 11, 12	Core	Precalculus
McDaniel	10, 11, 12	Core	Precalculus or Math 111/112
Roosevelt	11, 12	Elective	Precalculus

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Low Alignment: Courses with significant variation in grade availability, core vs. elective status, or prerequisites, potentially limiting student access.

- **Example:** AP Physics courses – Prerequisites and core/elective status differences create inconsistent access.

School	Grade(s) Offered	Core/Elective	Prerequisites
Benson	11, 12	Elective	NGSS Physics, C or better in Algebra 3-4, 2 credits of science
Franklin	10, 11, 12	Elective	NGSS Physics, Algebra 1-2
Grant	10, 11, 12	Elective	Geometry or enrollment in Algebra 3-4
Ida B Wells	11, 12	Core	NGSS Physics and NGSS Chemistry
McDaniel	11, 12	Core	Algebra 3-4
Roosevelt	10, 11, 12	Core	Geometry or enrolled in Algebra 3-4

While alignment across AP courses is a key issue, it is also important to acknowledge the disparities in outcomes, particularly for historically underserved student populations. The data underscores the need for targeted support structures to improve equitable access and success.

Next Steps: Engaging Stakeholders

We will engage with stakeholders to ensure a districtwide approach to AP access and alignment. The primary focus areas will include:

1. **Expanding equitable access** means ensuring that all students, particularly those from historically underserved backgrounds, have opportunities to enroll in AP courses.
2. **Improving alignment** – Refining course availability, prerequisites, and core/elective designations across the district.
3. **Enhancing student success** – Implementing additional supports to increase AP performance, particularly among students who have traditionally faced barriers.

Our next phase involves convening educators, administrators, counselors, and students to discuss these issues, gather feedback, and identify actionable solutions.

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Anticipated Outcomes

As we move through this work, we anticipate several key outcomes that will shape the future of AP in our district:

- **Administrative Directive on AP Course Alignment** – Establishing clear guidance on prerequisites, grade-level offerings, and core/elective designations.
- **Updated District Course Guide** – Aligning course descriptions and availability to reflect the findings from this review and stakeholder input.
- **Family Outreach and Communication Plan** – Ensuring families are well-informed about AP opportunities, pathways, and expectations.
- **Strengthened Systems and Supports for AP Success** – Expanding tutoring, teacher training, and other student supports to improve success rates, particularly for historically underserved students.

This work will lay the foundation for a more equitable, aligned, and effective AP program across the district. We look forward to engaging in these next steps and appreciate the leadership and collaboration that will make this effort successful.

Sincerely,

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